

MONCHO UNSCHOOLING

Cherry Blossoms (Hanami)

Unit Study

“For one short week each spring, whole cities stop to sit under trees that bloom, fall and vanish like pink snow, and you get to find out why the world holds its breath for it.”

Biology | Earth Science | Geography | History | Language Arts | Math | Art & Creativity | Life Skills & SEL | Chemistry | Music

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🧭 **How to use this guide:** This is not a workbook, and there's no answer key — on purpose! Every challenge is an invitation. Pick the ones that spark curiosity, skip the rest, and go find the answers by doing. **AI plans. Kids DO.** 🚀

🌸 BIOLOGY

Cherry blossoms are tiny living machines built to be found by insects, and every part of the flower has a job in that story.

🔬 Challenge 1: Flower Surgery

🎯 Plant Anatomy

What is hiding in the middle of a flower that you have never really looked at? ❓

You're the flower surgeon, and your patient is one cherry blossom (a real one, a photo, or a florist's cherry or plum branch).

1. Tape a sheet of paper in front of you and gently pull the flower apart, one part at a time.
2. Tape each petal down. Count them. A cherry blossom has 5, and each has a small notch at the tip.
3. Find the pedicel, the thin stalk that holds the flower up, and tape it down too.
4. Pull out the many thin stamens, tape them in a group, and count them.
5. Find the one pistil in the very center and tape it in the middle.
6. Label every part with a marker, using a magnifying glass or phone zoom to see tiny details.

Why: stamens make the pollen, and the pistil catches it, so this one small flower holds everything it needs to make seeds.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Skip the counting of stamens. Just find the petals, the stalk and the pistil, and label those three.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Dissect a second flower, such as a plum, apple or any garden blossom, and note which parts match and which are different.

🌱 Challenge 2: Bud Watch

🎯 Observing Change

What does a sleeping tree need before it wakes up and blooms? ❓

Bring a bare twig with buds indoors and put it in a jar of water on a sunny windowsill. A cherry, plum or forsythia twig works well.

1. Draw the twig and its buds on day 1.
2. Every day, at the same time, look closely and draw what changed: swelling, color, split scales, tiny petals.
3. Measure one bud with a ruler each day and write the number down.
4. Change the water every 2 or 3 days.
5. When a bud opens, count the days it took.

Now compare: your twig was warm and wet indoors, but a tree outside must first get through a cold winter rest called dormancy. Then it needs warming temperatures to bloom. In Japan, bloom dates are forecast mostly from temperature.

Why: a tree that bloomed during a warm spell in winter would lose its flowers to the next frost, so the cold rest works like an alarm clock that waits for real spring.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Watch just one bud and take a photo each day instead of drawing.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Set up a second twig in a cooler spot and compare which one opens first. Explain why you think so.

🐝 Challenge 3: The Pollen Play

🎯 Pollination

How does a flower that cannot walk send its pollen to another flower? ❓

Spend 15 minutes sitting near a flowering tree or flower patch and watch who visits.

1. Make a tally chart with columns for bees, flies, butterflies, beetles and other.
2. Add a tally mark every time an insect lands on a flower.
3. Note what each one does: does it crawl inside, drink, or collect pollen on its body?
4. Make colored dust to be your pollen, such as chalk scraped onto a plate or a pinch of cocoa powder.
5. Act it out with a friend or family member. One of you is a flower with stamens (dusty fingers), one is the bee that brushes against them, and one is a second flower with a pistil waiting to catch the dust.

Bees and other insects pollinate cherry flowers.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Count only the insects you spot in 5 minutes, then do the acting part without a tally chart.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a third flower to your play and show what would happen if the bee visited a flower of a different kind of plant.

🌍 EARTH SCIENCE

Cherry trees wake up by reading the weather, so Earth's climate decides when the whole world sits down for hanami.

🌡️ Challenge 1: Warm Twig, Cold Twig

🎯 Fair testing

Can a tree tell the difference between a warm spring and a cold one? ❓

1. Look up the average March temperature for Okinawa (about 18°C / 64°F) and for Hokkaido (around 0°C / 32°F). Write both numbers on a card.
2. Predict: which place will see cherry blossoms first? Write your guess and one reason.
3. Soak 6 dry beans in water overnight. Put 3 on a damp paper towel in a zip bag on a warm windowsill (your "Okinawa") and 3 in another bag in a cool spot, like a porch or an unheated room (your "Hokkaido").
4. Place a thermometer next to each bag and write down both temperatures every day.
5. Check the beans each day for a week and note which ones sprout first.
6. Compare your results with your prediction about the blossoms.

Why: Living plant parts, like seeds and flower buds, wake up faster when it's warm, so a warm place reaches that moment sooner than a cold one.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Skip the thermometer and just label the bags "warm" and "cold," then compare the beans with your eyes.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a third bag in a spot that is only a little cooler than the warm one, and draw a graph of temperature against how fast each bag of beans sprouted.

🗾 Challenge 2: Chase the Blossom Front

🎯 Map reading

How can a wave of flowers travel across a whole country? ❓

You're the forecaster. Each spring, the Japan Meteorological Agency tracks the "sakura zensen," the cherry blossom front. Blooming starts in the warm south, as early as January in Okinawa, and moves north until it reaches Hokkaido around May.

1. Print or draw a big outline of Japan's main islands, from Okinawa in the south up to Hokkaido in the north.
2. Mark five cities from south to north, such as Naha, Fukuoka, Tokyo, Sendai and Sapporo.
3. Look up each city's usual bloom date and pin or dot it on your map, writing the date beside it.
4. Join the dots in order with a colored line, then add small arrows to show the direction the front travels.
5. Use your dates to work out how many days the front takes to move from your first city to your last.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use only three cities (south, middle, north) and count the days on a calendar.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Predict the bloom date for a city you didn't mark by looking at where it sits between two pins, then check your guess online.

🌸 Challenge 3: Flower Blizzard Lab

🎯 Testing and recording

What does a petal need to let go: a shake, a splash or a puff of wind?❓

In Japan, falling petals are called "hanafubuki," a flower blizzard, and a petal-covered river is nicknamed "hanaikada," a flower raft. Let's find out what sets the blizzard off.

1. Ask an adult for a blooming branch (or a bunch of fresh flowers) and stand it in a jar of water over a tray or white sheet.
2. Shake the branch gently for 5 seconds. Count the petals that land on the tray and draw that many dots on a card under the label "Shake."
3. Clear the tray. Spray the branch with a water bottle for 5 seconds, count the petals, and draw dots under "Rain."
4. Clear the tray again. Blow on the branch with your breath or a paper fan for 5 seconds, count, and draw dots under "Wind."
5. Compare your three rows of dots and decide which kind of weather makes the biggest blizzard.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Compare just two things, shaking and blowing, and use the words "a few" or "a lot" instead of counting.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Repeat each test three times and find the average for each kind of weather, then try a "storm" that combines wind and rain.

🗺️ GEOGRAPHY

Cherry blossoms bloom in different places at different times, and travel across mountains, cities and even oceans.

🗻 Challenge 1: Build a Blossom Mountain

🎯 Elevation and landforms

Why would someone plant cherry trees in groves stacked up the side of a mountain instead of all in one spot? ❓

Mount Yoshino in Nara Prefecture is famous for about 30,000 cherry trees, planted in four groves rising up the mountainside. Build the slope they climb.

1. Cut 4 cardboard shapes, each one a bit smaller than the last, like a stack of pancakes. Or roll 4 flat clay slabs.
2. Glue or press them into a stepped mountain, biggest at the bottom.
3. Label the levels from bottom to top: Lower, Middle, Upper, Innermost.
4. Dot each level with a different colored paper or clay blossom to mark its grove, about 8-10 dots per level.
5. Put a toothpick flag at the bottom grove and another at the top. Walk your finger up the slope and say where you'd stand to see the whole mountain in pink.

Why: air gets cooler as you climb, so the groves higher up open their flowers later than the ones below, and the pink slowly climbs the mountain over several weeks.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use only 3 layers and draw the groves with colored pencils on the cardboard instead of making blossoms.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a paper "trail" winding up the mountain and mark where the steepest part is. Then decide where a visitor should rest, and explain why.

🚢 Challenge 2: Navigator's Route to Washington

🎯 Map and globe reading

How far did 3,000 tiny trees have to journey to become a gift across the world? ❓

You're the ship's navigator. In 1912, Tokyo gave about 3,000 cherry trees to Washington, D.C. as a gift of friendship, and Helen Taft and Viscountess Chinda planted the first two in March 1912. Plot the voyage.

1. Find Tokyo, Japan, on a globe and stick a small piece of tape or a pin there.
2. Find Washington, D.C., on the east coast of the United States and mark it too.
3. Tie a string to the first mark. Stretch it along the sea, over the Pacific Ocean, to the mark in Washington.
4. Note which oceans and continents your string crosses, and which ones it avoids.
5. Lay the string flat against a ruler and measure it. Then use the globe's scale to estimate the miles.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Only name the biggest ocean your string crosses and the two places it connects.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Make a second route going the opposite way, east around the globe, and compare which string is shorter.

🧺 Challenge 3: Plan the Perfect Picnic Spot

🎯 Bird's-eye maps

If hundreds of trees were blooming at once, where would you put your blanket to get the very best view? ❓

Choose Ueno Park or Shinjuku Gyoen, two famous hanami spots in Tokyo. Ueno Park is known for about 800 cherry trees.

1. Look at photos or a map of your park online or in a book.
2. On a big sheet of paper, draw the park from above, as a bird would see it: paths, ponds, lawns and the trees as little circles.
3. Mark your picnic blanket with a bright square.
4. Draw an arrow showing which way you'd look and what you'd see.
5. Write 2 reasons for your choice, like shade, open space or the view.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Draw only 10 trees and one path, then pick a blanket spot next to a tree.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a legend with at least 5 symbols and a scale bar, such as one thumb-width equals 50 steps.

📜 HISTORY

Long before cameras and trains, people in Japan were already gathering under cherry trees, and history shows us how a quiet spring habit grew into something whole countries share.

📜 Challenge 1: The First Blossom Party

🎯 Writing in role

What would a noble 1,200 years ago have packed for a party under a tree? ❓

You're a Heian court noble, and the emperor has asked you to plan a cherry-viewing party. By the Heian period (794-1185), cherry viewing had become a favorite court pastime.

1. Choose what you'd wear: layered robes in spring colors, a fan, maybe a hat.
2. Choose 3 foods and drinks you'd bring, using only things people could make then, with no plastic and no fridges.
3. Choose 2 things to do under the blossoms, like reciting poems or playing music.
4. Cut a long strip of paper, roll it from both ends like a scroll, and write the invitation to your guests, telling them what to wear, eat and do.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Draw your outfit, food and activities as pictures and add one short sentence to each.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a line to your invitation about what happens if it rains, and who sits closest to the best tree and why.

📜 Challenge 2: The Gift of Two Trees

🎯 Historical empathy

How can planting a tree become a promise between two countries? ❓

In 1912, Japan sent cherry trees as a gift to the United States, and the first two were planted in a ceremony in Washington. Now you'll act out that moment.

1. Pick the roles: someone from Japan, someone from the U.S., and a narrator. Use stuffed animals if you're working alone.
2. Make a pretend tree from a stick, paper blossoms and a pot of soil or sand.
3. Write 3 lines each for the two countries, saying what the gift means and what they hope for the future.
4. Perform it: speeches, the planting, and a handshake or a bow.

Why: Gifts have long been a way to build trust between countries, because a living tree needs years of care and shows you plan to stay friends.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Skip the writing and use just one sentence each: "Thank you," and "We will care for it."

🚀 **Level it Up:** Research one more thing the two countries have shared since then and add a final scene to your skit.

📜 Challenge 3: The Tree That Saw It All

🎯 Timelines

How many kings, emperors and wars can one tree watch go by? ❓

Jindai Zakura is a very old cherry tree in Japan, said to be about 2,000 years old. Imagine all it has lived through.

1. Tape sheets of paper together, or use a roll of paper, until you have a scroll at least 2 meters long.
2. Mark the far left as the tree's birth about 2,000 years ago and the far right as today.
3. Space out 8-10 events along the scroll in the right order, such as the Roman Empire, the first castles, the printing press and the invention of electricity. Ask an adult or use a library book to find dates.
4. Draw the tree in the middle of the scroll, with little scenes of each event around it.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use just 5 events and draw them in a row without worrying about exact spacing.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add the date of your birth and your family's story as the newest part of the tree's life.

📝 LANGUAGE ARTS

Cherry blossoms have inspired poets and word-lovers in Japan for centuries, so let's play with the words they use to talk about spring.

📝 Challenge 1: The Traveling Poet

🎯 Syllable counting

How can just seventeen sounds capture a whole spring day under a blooming tree? ❓

You're a traveling poet who has just reached a cherry tree in full bloom, like Matsuo Basho (1644-1694), the famous haiku poet who wrote about cherry blossoms. A haiku has 3 lines with a 5-7-5 sound pattern.

1. Look at a picture of blossoms, or a flowering tree outside, and jot down 6 words you notice.
2. Clap each sound as you say a word: "blos-som" is 2 claps, "pet-als" is 2 claps.
3. Build line 1 with 5 claps, line 2 with 7 claps, and line 3 with 5 claps.
4. Write three haiku this way, then copy them neatly onto folded paper pages and add a title and your poet name on the cover.

Why: English counts syllables, which are small sound beats, and clapping makes each beat easy to hear and count.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Write just one haiku and use the 6 words you jotted down in step 1. Clap each line out loud before you write it.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Write all three poems about the same tree at three different moments: bud, full bloom, and falling petals.

📝 Challenge 2: Flower-Name Detective

🎯 Compound words

What happens when you glue two small words together to make a brand-new one?❓

Japanese builds words from small pieces. Hanami means "flower viewing": hana = flower and mi = looking. The cherry tree itself is called sakura.

1. With a grown-up, look up hana and mi on jisho.org (a free Japanese-English dictionary) and see how other words use those same pieces.
2. Take a walk around your home or neighborhood and spot 8 things you could name.
3. Invent a pretend-Japanese-style compound word for each, like "rain + window" or "toast + butter."
4. Make a mini picture-dictionary: write each invented word, its meaning, and a tiny sketch beside it.
5. Read your words aloud to someone and see if they can guess each meaning before you reveal it.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Invent only 4 words, and use pairs from things on your own desk or table.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Make 12 words, and add a 3-piece word like "sun + tea + cup."

📝 Challenge 3: Word-Building Card Game

🎯 Word parts

Can you make a brand-new word just by shuffling the pieces of old ones?❓

Time to play with the building blocks you found: hana (flower), mi (looking), and sakura (cherry tree).

1. Cut 12 small cards from paper. Write hana on 3 cards, mi on 3 cards, and sakura on 3 cards.
2. On the last 3 cards, write your own word pieces, like "moon" or "snow."
3. Shuffle, deal 3 cards each, and take turns laying down two cards to build a compound word.
4. Say what your new word could mean, like "moon-mi" for moon-looking. If everyone agrees it makes sense, keep the pair as a point.
5. Whoever has the most pairs when the cards run out wins.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Play with only the hana and mi cards, and lay down your words for others to read aloud.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a rule that every new word needs a one-sentence example, like a tiny poem line.

🌸 MATH

Every spring, Japan counts blossoms, angles and snacks, because even a party under the trees runs on numbers.

🌸 Challenge 1: Count the Bloom!

🎯 Percentages

How many open flowers does a tree need before everyone agrees it is in full bloom? ❓

You're the official bloom counter for a cherry tree. In Japan, "kaika" (first bloom) is declared when at least about 5 blossoms open on a reference tree, and "mankai" (full bloom) when about 80% of buds are open.

1. Cut out 10 small paper buds. These are your tree's buds, so each one is 10%.
2. Draw a 100-square grid (10 by 10) on paper. Every square is 1%.
3. Show first bloom: color just 5 squares pink. Notice how tiny that is next to the whole grid.
4. Show full bloom: color 80 squares pink. Count them by rows of ten.
5. Flip over 8 of your paper buds to "open." Write the fraction: 8 out of 10 = 80/100.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Skip the 100-grid. Use only your 10 paper buds and flip over 5, then 8, writing "__ out of 10" each time.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Make a new tree of 20 paper buds. How many must be open for full bloom? Then work out how many are open at 25%, 50% and 75%.

🌸 Challenge 2: Five-Petal Blossom

🎯 Angles and Symmetry

How can one flat piece of paper turn into a flower with five perfectly matching petals? ❓

Cherry blossoms have five petals, and a full circle is 360 degrees. Let's see what that means for your flower.

1. Cut a paper circle. Fold it in half, then fold it into a cone shape so it has 5 equal wedges. Fold one side about a third of the way over, fold the other side over it, and tuck it into a neat cone.
2. Trim the top edge of the cone with a curve, then cut a small notch in the middle of the curved edge.
3. Unfold your flower. You should see 5 petals around the center.
4. Put a protractor on the center and measure the angle from the tip of one petal to the tip of the next.
5. Check your math: 360 ÷ 5 = 72. Is your measurement close to 72 degrees?

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Skip the protractor. Fold a second flower the same way and lay it over the first to check that all five wedges match exactly.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Try folding a six-petal and an eight-petal flower. Predict each angle first by dividing 360, then measure to see how close you got.

🍡 Challenge 3: Dango Picnic Budget

🎯 Budgeting and Division

How many dumplings does it take to feed a whole family under the blossoms? ❓

You're the picnic planner. Hanami picnics often include hanami dango, three-color pink, white and green rice dumplings on a stick, and sakura mochi, a sweet rice cake wrapped in a pickled cherry leaf. Your job is to plan the dango.

1. Count how many people are coming to your picnic.
2. Decide how many sticks each person gets. Each stick has 3 dumplings, so how many dumplings is that for one person? For everyone?
3. Make up a price, such as $2 per stick. Multiply to find the total cost.
4. Pretend you have a $20 budget. Do you have enough? If not, how many sticks can you afford?
5. Write your shopping list with the numbers, prices and total.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Plan for just 4 people with 1 stick each, and use a price of $1 per stick so the adding is simple.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a second treat with its own made-up price. Fit both inside one $30 budget, then work out how much money you'd have left for drinks.

🎨 ART & CREATIVITY

Cherry blossoms last such a short time that people have been painting, folding and crafting them for centuries to hold on to the moment.

🖌️ Challenge 1: One Brush, Few Strokes

🎯 Brush Painting

How can a few simple strokes make a branch look alive? ❓

The Somei Yoshino, the most widely planted cherry for hanami, has pale pink-white flowers with 5 petals, and they open before the leaves appear. That means the branch is bare and dark, with blossoms dotted all along it. Perfect for sumi-e!

1. Mix black ink or very dark watercolor with water. Test it on scrap paper: more water makes grey, less water makes black.
2. With one brush, paint a branch in a few strokes. Press hard for thick wood, lift the brush for thin twigs. Let it zigzag.
3. Rinse the brush and dip it in pink watercolor. Dab small round blossoms along the twigs, clustering some and leaving gaps.
4. Add a few dots of darker pink at the centers, but add no leaves.
5. Step back. Can you remove one stroke and still have a branch?

Why: in sumi-e, empty paper is part of the picture, so the white space becomes sky and air.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Paint only a straight branch and use a cotton swab to dab on the blossoms.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Paint the same branch three times, each with fewer strokes than the last, and pick the one that says the most with the least.

🌸 Challenge 2: Blossom Branch in a Vase

🎯 3D Sculpting

Can you build a branch that stays in bloom longer than the real thing? ❓

A single blossom lasts only about a week, and a tree is at its fullest for only a few days. In Japan this is linked to *mono no aware*, a feeling for the fleeting nature of life. Build a branch that doesn't fade.

1. Find a real stick with a few side branches and stand it in a vase, held with pebbles or modeling clay.
2. Cut tissue paper into squares about 6 cm wide, in pale pink and white.
3. Pinch the center of a square and twist it, so the edges ruffle into 5 petal-like folds.
4. Wrap a bit of thin wire or a twist tie around the pinch, then tie each blossom to the stick. Space them unevenly, with clusters and gaps.
5. Make about 20 blossoms, some bigger and some smaller, and fill your branch.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Skip the wire and glue flat tissue-paper flowers right onto the stick.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Make a few half-open buds and a couple of fallen petals on the table, so your branch shows blooming, peak and falling all at once.

🍂 Challenge 3: One Tree, Four Seasons

🎯 Collage Technique

How would one tree look if you could see its whole year at once? ❓

Sakura trees belong to the genus *Prunus*, the same genus as plums, peaches and almonds. And like their relatives, they look completely different in each season.

1. Fold a big sheet of paper into four panels: winter, spring, summer and autumn.
2. Gather scraps from the recycling bin: magazine pages, fabric, cardboard and dry leaves.
3. Tear (don't cut!) shapes to build the same tree in each panel. Soft, torn edges look like bark and petals.
4. Winter gets bare brown branches, spring gets pink-white blossoms, summer gets a thick green canopy, and autumn gets orange and red leaves. Some *Prunus* trees turn bright red or gold in fall, so peek outside or look at photos for color ideas.
5. Layer pieces on top of each other before gluing to give the trees depth. Hang it where you'll see it every day.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Make just two panels, spring and autumn, with fewer layers.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Hide one small surprise in every panel, like a bird, a bud or a bee, and challenge someone to find all four.

🧺 LIFE SKILLS & SEL

Hanami is a party with a plan behind it, and planning ahead, sharing space and cleaning up are skills that make the whole thing work.

🧺 Challenge 1: Keeper of the Picnic Spot

🎯 Planning ahead

What does it take to share a beautiful spot so everyone can enjoy it and it looks untouched when you leave? ❓

During hanami season, families sometimes send someone early just to hold a good spot under the trees. Now it's your turn to plan one.

1. Pick a blanket and spread it in a spot at home or in a nearby park with an adult, leaving walking room around it.
2. Make a "What to Bring" list: three things to sit on or use, three things to eat or drink, and one thing for fun.
3. Write a "Leave No Trace" checklist with at least five items, like "carry out every wrapper" and "check under the blanket."
4. Add a short "Saving the Spot" list: who stays, who fetches food, and how you'll be polite to neighbors.
5. Do a practice cleanup and tick off each item.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Make just the "What to Bring" list with drawings instead of words, plus three cleanup rules.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a plan for rain and a job chart so each family member has a task before, during and after the picnic.

🌸 Challenge 2: The Feelings Jar

🎯 Mindfulness

Why can something feel more precious because it won't last? ❓

1. Find a fresh flower, a leaf or a blade of grass, and sit somewhere quiet.
2. Set a timer for five minutes. Look at your object without talking. Notice its colors, edges, smell and tiny details.
3. When the timer rings, draw it, or tell someone how you feel about the fact that all flowers fade eventually.
4. Write three feelings on separate slips of paper, such as "calm," "a little sad" or "grateful."
5. Fold the slips and drop them into a clean jar.

Why: Slowing down to notice small details gives your brain time to feel, not just look. That's why a quiet pause can make ordinary things seem special.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Sit for two minutes instead of five and write just one feeling word.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Repeat the five-minute sit on three different days with a new object each time, and compare what you felt.

🎒 Challenge 3: The First Day Welcome

🎯 Empathy and communication

What would make a brand-new student feel like they belong on the very first day? ❓

In Japan, the school and business year starts in April, right when cherry blossoms open, so the trees are tied to new beginnings, entrance ceremonies and first days of school.

You're a new student's welcome buddy.

1. Think of a time you started something new. Write down three words for how it felt.
2. Prepare a welcome: a greeting, a short tour of one room, and one question that helps the newcomer feel at ease.
3. Role-play it with a family member as the new student, then switch roles.
4. Interview a grown-up in your family: "What do you remember about your first day of school or a new job? What helped you feel better?"
5. Jot down their answers and one tip you'll use as a welcome buddy.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Practice only the greeting and one friendly question, and ask the family member just one interview question.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Add a handwritten welcome card for the new student, with three kind things you would say and one way you'd help them make a friend.

🧪 CHEMISTRY

Chemistry is what turns a branch of buds into pink clouds, and it's also how you can make colors change in your own kitchen.

🧪 Challenge 1: Color-Change Magic

🎯 Acids and bases

Can a purple juice turn pink, then green, just by adding things from your kitchen? ❓

1. Ask an adult to help you chop 2 cups of red cabbage, pour hot (not boiling) water over it, and let it sit 15 minutes. Strain out the leaves. The purple liquid is your indicator.
2. Line up 4 clear jars and pour 3 spoonfuls of cabbage juice into each.
3. Squeeze lemon juice into jar 1, a little at a time. Watch it turn pink.
4. Leave jar 2 alone, then stir a pinch of baking soda into jar 3. Add more to jar 4 until it turns blue-green.
5. Add a few drops of lemon to jar 3 and watch the color travel backward.

Why: Cherry blossoms are pink because of pigments called anthocyanins, and red cabbage has them too. These pigments change color depending on whether they're sitting in an acid (like lemon) or a base (like baking soda).

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Skip the chopping: ask an adult to do it, and test only two jars, one with lemon and one with baking soda.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Test other kitchen liquids like vinegar, soapy water, milk and fizzy water. Predict each color first, then sort them from most acidic to most basic.

🍡 Challenge 2: Sticky Rice Transformation

🎯 Heat changes matter

How can hard, dry grains of rice turn into something you can mold like clay? ❓

You're the sakura chef, preparing a spring picnic treat. People have been celebrating cherry blossoms with food for a very long time.

1. Take 1 cup of dry sticky rice and rub a few grains between your fingers. Notice how hard and separate they feel.
2. Soak the rice in water for 30 minutes, then cook it with an adult, either steamed or simmered in a covered pot with a little extra water, until soft.
3. Let it cool until it's warm, not hot. Divide it into three bowls and tint one pink and one green with a drop of food coloring, leaving one white.
4. With damp hands, roll small balls and slide three colors onto a skewer, pink, white, green.

Why: Heat and water make the starch in the rice swell and burst open, and the starch turns sticky and gluey instead of hard.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use leftover cooked sticky rice and skip the coloring: just shape white balls.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Cook a batch of regular rice the same way and compare it to the sticky rice: which one holds its shape, and what do you notice about the texture?

🎵 MUSIC

Cherry blossom season has its own songs, and one tune has been sung under the trees for generations.

🎶 Challenge 1: Five Notes Under the Trees

🎯 Melody

How can just five notes be enough to make people feel the quiet beauty of spring? ❓

"Sakura Sakura" is a famous Japanese folk song, and its opening phrase uses very few notes. Build a row of bottle "xylophone" keys and play it.

1. Line up 5 identical glass bottles or jars. Fill them with different amounts of water, the least in the first bottle and the most in the last.
2. Tap each with a metal spoon and listen. Add or pour out water until the pitches climb from low to high in steps. Number them 1 to 5.
3. Play the opening phrase of "Sakura Sakura" using the number pattern 3-3-4, 3-3-4, then 3-4-5-4-3-4-3-2-1 (or find a recording and match it by ear).
4. Hum along while you play, one tap for each syllable: "Sa-ku-ra, sa-ku-ra."
5. Play the phrase slowly and gently, with a pause at the end, for a family member or a stuffed-animal audience.

Why: when you tap the glass, the water inside makes it vibrate more slowly, so more water means a lower pitch and less water means a higher pitch.

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Play just the first six notes (3-3-4, 3-3-4) over and over until it feels smooth, then add the rest.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Move the whole tune higher or lower by shifting every number one bottle over, then see if you can play it from memory with your eyes closed.

🌸 Challenge 2: Petal Storm Orchestra

🎯 Rhythm and Dynamics

How can a soft tap grow into a whirlwind of sound without a single melody note? ❓

When wind blows blossoms off the branches all at once, the Japanese call it hanafubuki. Compose a piece that sounds exactly like it, using only sounds from your kitchen and desk.

1. Gather three "instruments": a handful of dry rice in a bowl or tin, a sheet of paper to crinkle and rub, and your fingertips to tap on a table.
2. Start with one soft fingertip tap, then wait. That is the first petal drifting down.
3. Add more taps, then gently shake the rice, then crinkle the paper. Get louder and faster, like the wind picking up.
4. Reach your loudest, fullest moment. Then slowly thin out the sounds until only one last tap remains.
5. Perform your petal storm with your eyes closed, or have a listener close theirs. Can they hear the petals fall?

🌱 **Make it Easier:** Use only two sounds, rice and taps, and just count "1, 2, 3, 4, 5" getting louder, then "5, 4, 3, 2, 1" getting softer.

🚀 **Level it Up:** Write your piece as a score on paper using dots for taps and wavy lines for rustling, then trade scores with someone and play each other's storms.